Gaston Wiet

Inv. no. A.6



Portrait of Gaston Wiet, c.1940 (Archive of the Museum of Islamic Art, Cairo)

For 25 years, from 1926 to 1951, the French orientalist Gaston Wiet directed the institution known today as the Museum of Islamic Art. One of the most prominent scholars of the region, Wiet was born in Paris in 1887 into a family of translators; he first came to Cairo in 1909 as a resident scholar at the French Institute of Oriental Archaeology before returning to France as a professor of Arabic and Turkish language in Lyon. During the First World War he served in the French Army and ended the war with the rank of captain.



Official Wooden Seal of Gaston Wiet, Museum of Islamic Art, Cairo, c. 1926-51

Wiet was the last foreign director of the Museum of Islamic Art, initially appointed in 1926 as a temporary solution until the museum could find a suitable Egyptian candidate. Instead, he excelled in the role, and his command of Arabic, academic knowledge, and diplomatic skill saw him remain as the museum's director for a quarter of a century. In that time, he persuaded the Egyptian authorities of the museum's importance and oversaw a major expansion of its collections. Cairo was then regarded as the capital of Arab art, and it had an active antiquities market. Many important pieces were bought from dealers, which was normal practice for museums at the time. Wiet also wrote 14 volumes of the museum's catalogue.

Alongside his work at the museum, Wiet taught Islamic art history at the Louvre from 1933 to 1937 and lectured on Islamic art at the Oriental University of Beirut in 1937. He was a prolific writer and a leading specialist in Arabic inscriptions, authoring several important publications, most notably the History of the Egyptian Nation. He also produced the first French translations of several Arabic texts.

In 1951, Wiet returned to France, where he was chair of Arabic language and Literature at the Collège de France until 1959. He died in 1971.

Many of the objects in this exhibition entered the collection during Wiet's directorship. They are shown alongside his official seal and documents from the museum's archive.

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